2.1 The Tejanos

When Mexico took control of the territory that later became Texas, the Mexican government was concerned about how few people lived there. The solution? Offer free land and hope people would move there.

MAIN IDEA After achieving independence from Spain, Mexico encouraged American settlement in the territory of Texas.

SPANISH TERRITORY

In the early 1800s, some westward-bound Americans ended up in Spanish territory. What we know today as the state of Texas used to be the Spanish territory called **Tejas** (TAY-hahs). In 1598, Spanish conquistador Juan de Oñate (oh-NYAH-tay) and his soldiers reached the Rio Grande. De Oñate claimed all the land around the river for Spain, leading to 200 years of Spanish rule.

Tejas lay north of the Nueces (noo-AY-suhs) River and extended into present-day Louisiana. Spain established missions throughout the area, starting with San Francisco de los Tejas. Catholic priests and missionaries moved to these missions in order to convert the Coahuiltecan (koh-uh-WEEL-tek-un) and the Caddo (KAH-doh) people. **Presidios**, or military settlements, surrounded most missions. Other Spanish settlers built farms close to the presidios.

Tejas shared a border with the United States. As a result, Spain worried about the influence its northern neighbor might have on the territory. Settlers of Spanish or Mexican descent, called **Tejanos** (tay-HAH-nohs), were forbidden to trade with other countries. Even so, many Americans entered the territory illegally to do business with Tejanos. Spanish authorities pursued and arrested Americans who did so. Meanwhile, many Native Americans attacked Spanish settlements because they were resentful that Spain limited their chances to trade with the United States and suspicious of the actions of Spanish missionaries. Spain tried to maintain peace with Native Americans in Tejas because it wanted to remain in control of the region. But the Spanish were unable to bring about stability there.



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A bronze statue of a Tejano sitting astride his horse is part of the striking Tejano Monument, located on the grounds of the Texas state capitol in Austin. The monument honors the contributions of Tejanos and their roles in shaping Tejas—and eventually Texas.

LAND GRANTS AND SETTLERS

After an 11-year war, Mexico won its independence from Spain. As a result, in 1821, the Tejanos found themselves part of Mexico and no longer under Spanish rule. The new nation of Mexico included the lands that make up present-day Texas, New Mexico, Arizona, California, Nevada, and Utah, as well as parts of Colorado and Wyoming.

Few people lived in Tejas, and the Mexican government feared conflicts between Tejano settlements and Native Americans. Hoping that a larger population of settlers would stabilize the territory, Mexico encouraged American immigration and settlement and, unlike Spain, welcomed trade with Americans.

The Mexican government also gave land grants to American farmers and merchants. One American merchant received permission to form a colony even before Mexican independence. In 1820, Moses Austin persuaded the Spanish governor to allow him to bring a few hundred families to settle in Tejas. He died a year later, before he could carry out his plan, but his son, **Stephen F. Austin**, inherited the land grant. Austin moved 300 American families into southeastern Tejas, establishing the territory's first legal American settlement. A rush of other American immigrants soon followed.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What influence did Mexican independence have on Americans' presence in Tejas?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What did Mexico hope to accomplish through the land grants?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Based on details you notice on the map, describe the borders and territory of Mexico in 1821.

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